



**“The entry level car will always be the biggest seller in India. There is a lot of pent-up demand. Right now they [Maruti] are short of SUVs, but they will come back”**

**ASHOK KAPUR**  
CHAIRMAN & MD,  
KRISHNA GROUP



**“CNG is here to stay because now there are no issues of pumps even in small districts. The kind of customer interest we’re seeing is very strong and it’s very economical as compared to ICE”**

**VINKESH GULATI**  
PRESIDENT, FADA



**“Within SUVs, people prefer compact SUVs... the entry level car segment is under major threat... Customer preference is shifting from small cars to compact SUVs”**

**MITUL SHAH**  
HEAD OF RESEARCH,  
RELIANCE SECURITIES

**38 |** reason, instead of rushing too far ahead and focussing solely on advancing technologies, we must first consider what kinds of vehicles our customers will actually need and use in the coming years,” says its 2021 annual report.

**F**INALLY, CONCERNS ON Maruti’s falling market share in passenger vehicles are met with confidence. Bhargava says it is a result of customers falling out from the buying segment of the population that has shrunk the market. “Maruti still has the strongest balance sheet of any car company in India and I suppose, even globally,” he asserts. FADA is confident of Maruti’s bounce back. “Once they solve their production issues and launch their future line-up, which has some compact SUVs, we don’t expect them to be back at 50-55 per cent immediately, but volume-wise they will be back,” says Gulati.

Ashok Kapur, who founded the Krishna Group in 1994, starting with manufacturing of seating systems for the iconic Maruti 800 and then branching into scores of other products and locations, says Maruti will go back to 50 per cent share in two to three years. “The entry level car will always be the biggest seller in India. There is a lot of pent-up demand. Right now they’re short of SUVs, but they’ll come back. They have a lot of advantages like customer loyalty, sales net-

work, service quality, etc.,” says Kapur, who is CMD of the Krishna Group and also President of Maruti Suzuki Suppliers Welfare Association.

Kenichi Ayukawa, the outgoing CEO and current Vice Chairman and Whole-time Director of Maruti, says that one needs to change as per the changing environment in order to survive. “To me, this is the foundation of the success for any business and its sustainability. The basic reason for establishing Maruti Suzuki was to provide affordable cars to the Indian families. That is the philosophy of the company and accordingly we continue to try and deliver more cars to Indian customers. Of course, business challenges will continue to evolve. Changes in technology, customer preference and many more aspects will surely bring more challenges. However, I am confident that Maruti Suzuki will overcome these with determination and emerge successful.”

Takeuchi has an interesting take: “Had I got this leadership opportunity when the company was enjoying 53 per cent market share, it would have been very tough to maintain and make it even better. Now, it’s a good time for me to try and make some recovery gradually, and we have a strong product plan to do that.”

It’s time for Takeuchi to make the perfect lemonade for India. **BT**

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